In writing this book, I offer four core arguments. First, that migration or spatial mobility is not a recent phenomenon in India in scale or variety and that the country currently sustains the world's largest and longest voluntary migration episode in migration history, what I call the Great Indian Migration Wave. Second, the history of migration in India has often been closely bound with the idea of 'circulation'. Third, migration and circulation have not influenced all sub-groups evenly and, in particular, the lack of substantive spatial mobility continues to disempower the lowest-ranking castes of India. Finally, I argue that greater spatial mobility is a prerequisite for maintaining the pluralistic traditions of the country.

Writing a book of this nature, wide in scope and reasonably concise, requires certain maxims and justifications for the regions and time periods chosen. In general, I cover those topics that have been well-researched and have some body of evidence. This is important to state because virtually every Indian community has an origin myth that is fascinating to hear and is plausibly true but extremely hard to verify. I also lay more emphasis on regions that appear to have a larger demographic weightage in Indian migration history. I use the old and new names of places interchangeably, usually denoting the names as they were used in the time period being discussed. The printing of maps on the Indian subcontinent has been constrained due to recently revised publication guidelines.

This book is the culmination of an exciting decade-long academic and personal adventure that began with my doctoral research on migration history at the Indian Institute of Management Bangalore (IIMB). A year at the Migration Policy Centre of the European University Institute in Florence, Italy, and another year on a parental break spent in reading books at St Louis, USA, helped me appreciate the contemporary and historical migration challenges faced in Europe, Africa and the Americas. The experience of teaching urban studies at the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) Hyderabad and the 'HitchHiker's Guide to Business and Economies across Five Centuries' at IIM Ahmedabad opened new angles on migration history (and the writings of Douglas Adams) that I had not explored previously. As a member of a ministry-appointed working group on